Though the number of subscriptions was considerable, and the sums realized not insubstantial, the capital actually raised was quite short of what the company needed. It should also be noted that when shares were subscribed to, the shareholders did not pay up the face value. It was to be paid in five instalments, and often, subscribers, after their initial enthusiasm did not follow it up for any number of reasons: fear, lack of resources, absence of agents to prod them, etc.

Though it was only a year later that donations were sought instead of shares, even in late 1908 other, unprofessional, methods were used. A desperate move, described by the CID as 'the straits to which [SSNCo] was reduced appear from the terms of "An Ardent and Humble Appeal" distributed among the Tirunelveli Hindu College's students'. (It is worth noting that the students and some teachers of the Hindu College had played a stellar role in the Tirunelveli 'Riots'.) Nothing is known of its authors, but it appealed for a contribution of one rupee from each student from the money set aside for the examination fees. Pleading with students for supporting the company 'founded by our dear brother, Sri V.O. Chidambaram Pillai', it reminded them that the date for final instalment 'for the pretty *Gallia* was fast approaching like our University due date'; and their contribution would be a token of appreciation of 'the noble self-sacrifice of Sri V.O. Chidambaram Pillai and others'. The contributions were to be remitted to the Chennai Jana Sangam.[118]

Other efforts were also afoot. In an attempt to target the right audience, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar, using paid employees, circulated an appeal at the annual session of the Congress in Madras in December 1908—its first session after the split in Surat. This leaflet, titled 'The Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company. Its Past and Future Before it. An Appeal', drew extensively from the company's annual report of 1908. The hope was that the relatively affluent nationalist delegates—even though of moderate persuasion—coming from all over India would give a helping hand to the company.[119] Ironically, this innocuous appeal had the unintended effect of stirring an unpleasant controversy.